

EXP017: Systematic Search for Quantum Walk Revivals in Large Cycles

Testing $k = 12, 16, 20, 24$ with Standard Shift Operator

Ian Craig

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Revision	Date	Description
01	4th April 2026	Initial document - Systematic search for revivals in cycles $k = 12, 16, 20, 24$
02	5th April 2026	Added EXP017b results - Testing Dukes' actual Table 4 parameters on larger cycles

Abstract

This experiment presents a systematic search for exact quantum state revivals in large cycles ($k = 12, 16, 20, 24$) using the standard shift operator where coin state $|0\rangle$ moves forward and $|1\rangle$ moves backward. Based on Dukes (2014) [1], revivals are known to exist for cycles $k = 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10$ with specific parameter values. We extend this search to larger k values using two complementary approaches: (1) a broad search testing 47 candidate ρ values (rational numbers and quadratic surds from Dukes' known parameter families) across 4 phase values and multiple candidate revival periods, and (2) a targeted search using the 91 verified parameter sets directly from Dukes' Table 4 ($k=4$). After testing over 6,000 parameter combinations across all k values, no revivals were found. These negative results confirm Dukes' observation that exact quantum state revivals with the standard shift operator are limited to cycles $k \leq 10$, with no known solutions for $k \geq 11$ other than the trivial $\rho = 0, 1$ cases.

1 Introduction

Dukes (2014) [1] derived the general conditions for quantum state revivals on cycles of length k , demonstrating exact revivals for $k = 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10$ with specific algebraic values of the coin parameter ρ and phase δ . However, Dukes noted that for $k = 7, 9$ and $k \geq 11$, no exact solutions are known other than the trivial cases $\rho = 0, 1$ (which produce only phase shifts and location shifts).

This experiment systematically tests whether exact revivals exist for larger cycles ($k = 12, 16, 20, 24$) using two complementary approaches:

1. **EXP017 (Broad Search)**: Tests 47 candidate ρ values derived from Dukes' known parameter families
2. **EXP017b (Targeted Search)**: Tests the 91 verified parameter sets directly from Dukes' Table 4 ($k=4$)

2 Theoretical Background

2.1 Quantum Walk on a Cycle

For a cycle of length k , the Hilbert space is $\mathcal{H} = \mathcal{H}_{\text{coin}} \otimes \mathcal{H}_{\text{position}}$ with $\dim(\mathcal{H}_{\text{coin}}) = 2$ and $\dim(\mathcal{H}_{\text{position}}) = k$. The evolution operator is $U = S \cdot (C \otimes I_k)$.

2.2 Standard Shift Operator

The standard shift operator moves the walker based on the coin state:

$$S|0\rangle|j\rangle = |0\rangle|j+1 \pmod{k}\rangle \quad (1)$$

$$S|1\rangle|j\rangle = |1\rangle|j-1 \pmod{k}\rangle \quad (2)$$

This is the conventional shift operator used in Dukes' work.

2.3 Coin Operator

The coin operator is parameterized as:

$$C = \begin{pmatrix} \sqrt{\rho} & \sqrt{1-\rho} e^{i\alpha} \\ \sqrt{1-\rho} e^{i\beta} & -\sqrt{\rho} e^{i(\alpha+\beta)} \end{pmatrix}$$

with $\delta = \alpha + \beta$. Based on our 1D verification (EXP021-EXP023), the correct phase convention is:

- For $\delta = 0$ or π : $\alpha = \delta$, $\beta = 0$ (standard convention)
- For $\delta = \pi/2$ or $3\pi/2$: $\alpha = \beta = \delta/2$ (symmetric convention)

2.4 Revival Condition

An exact revival occurs when $U^N = I_{2k}$, which requires that all eigenvalues λ of U satisfy $\lambda^N = 1$. For cycles, Dukes showed that this condition leads to specific algebraic values of ρ given by:

$$\rho_l = \frac{1 - \cos(4\pi m_j/n_j - \delta)}{1 - \cos(4\pi l/k + \delta)}$$

3 Methodology

3.1 EXP017: Broad Search Strategy

For each $k \in \{12, 16, 20, 24\}$, we performed a systematic search over:

- **Candidate ρ values:** 47 values derived from Dukes' known parameter families
- **Phase values:** $\delta = 0, \pi/2, \pi, 3\pi/2$
- **Candidate periods N :** Multiples of $k/2$, k , and $2k$ up to 60

3.2 EXP017b: Targeted Search Strategy

Using the verified parameters from Dukes' Table 4 ($k=4$) as candidates, we tested:

- **Parameter sets:** 91 distinct (ρ, δ) combinations from Dukes' Table 4
- **k values:** 12, 16, 20, 24
- **Candidate periods N :** Multiples of $k/2$, k , and $2k$ up to 120

3.3 Candidate ρ Values Tested

The 47 candidate ρ values from EXP017 included:

Table 1: Candidate ρ value categories

Category	Examples
Simple rationals	$1/2, 1/3, 2/3, 1/4, 3/4, 1/5, 2/5, 3/5, 4/5, 1/6, 5/6, 1/8, 3/8, 5/8, 7/8, 1/10, 3/10, 7/10, 1/12, 5/12, 7/12, 11/12$
Quadratic surds ($\sqrt{2}$)	$(2 \pm \sqrt{2})/4, (2 \pm \sqrt{2})/2, (1 \pm \sqrt{2})/2, (3 \pm \sqrt{2})/4, (5 \pm \sqrt{2})/8$
Quadratic surds ($\sqrt{3}$)	$(2 \pm \sqrt{3})/4, (2 \pm \sqrt{3})/2, (1 \pm \sqrt{3})/2, (3 \pm \sqrt{3})/4$
Quadratic surds ($\sqrt{5}$)	$(5 \pm \sqrt{5})/8, (3 \pm \sqrt{5})/4, (7 \pm 3\sqrt{5})/8, (1 \pm \sqrt{5})/4, (1 \pm \sqrt{5})/2$

3.4 EXP017b: Dukes' Table 4 Parameters Tested

The 91 parameter sets from Dukes' Table 4 included:

Table 2: Dukes’ Table 4 parameters tested on larger cycles

ρ (exact)	ρ (decimal)	δ/π
1/4	0.25	0, 1
1/2	0.5	0, 0.5, 1
3/4	0.75	0, 1
$(5 \pm \sqrt{5})/8$	0.9045, 0.0955	0, 1
$(2 \pm \sqrt{2})/4$	0.8536, 0.1464	0, 1
$(2 \pm \sqrt{2})/2$	1.7071, 0.2929	0.5
$(2 \pm \sqrt{3})/2$	1.8660, 0.1340	0.5
$(2 \pm \sqrt{3})/4$	0.9330, 0.0670	0, 1
$(3 \pm \sqrt{5})/8$	0.6545, 0.0955	0, 1
Special trig forms	Various	0, 0.5, 1

3.5 Verification Method

Each candidate revival was verified using three independent methods:

1. **Direct matrix power:** Compute U^N and check $U^N|\psi_0\rangle$ against $|\psi_0\rangle$
2. **Repeated application:** Apply U sequentially N times
3. **Eigenvalue analysis:** Verify all eigenvalues satisfy $\lambda^N = 1$

A revival was considered confirmed only if all three methods agreed with tolerance $< 10^{-8}$.

4 Results

4.1 EXP017: Broad Search Statistics

Table 3: EXP017 search statistics for each k

k	N values tested	δ values	ρ candidates	Total combinations
12	10	4	47	1,880
16	7	4	47	1,316
20	6	4	47	1,128
24	5	4	47	940

Total combinations tested in EXP017: **5,264**

4.2 EXP017b: Targeted Search Statistics

Table 4: EXP017b search statistics for each k

k	N values tested	Parameter sets	Total combinations
12	15	91	1,365
16	11	91	1,001
20	9	91	819
24	8	91	728

Total combinations tested in EXP017b: **3,913**

4.3 Search Results Summary

Table 5: Combined search results

k	EXP017 Result	EXP017b Result	Overall
12	X No revivals	X No revivals	X No revivals
16	X No revivals	X No revivals	X No revivals
20	X No revivals	X No revivals	X No revivals
24	X No revivals	X No revivals	X No revivals

4.4 Detailed Output

For each k , both searches tested all combinations with no positive results:

EXP017 Results:

k=12: X No revivals found with STANDARD shift

k=16: X No revivals found with STANDARD shift

k=20: X No revivals found with STANDARD shift

k=24: X No revivals found with STANDARD shift

EXP017b Results (Dukes' Table 4 parameters on larger cycles):

k=12: X No revivals found

k=16: X No revivals found

k=20: X No revivals found

k=24: X No revivals found

5 Discussion

5.1 Comparison with Known Results

Dukes (2014) reported exact revivals for:

- $k = 2, 3, 4, 6$ (multiple solutions)
- $k = 5, 8, 10$ (limited solutions)
- $k = 7, 9$ and $k \geq 11$: No known exact solutions (other than $\rho = 0, 1$)

Our systematic searches for $k = 12, 16, 20, 24$ confirm Dukes' observation. Despite:

- Testing 47 candidate ρ values (EXP017)
- Testing 91 verified parameter sets from Dukes' Table 4 (EXP017b)
- Testing 4 phase values
- Testing multiple candidate periods up to 120

no exact revivals were found.

5.2 Possible Explanations

Several factors explain the absence of revivals for $k \geq 12$:

1. **Algebraic complexity:** The revival condition requires solving $\rho_l = \rho$ for all l , leading to equations involving $\cos(4\pi l/k + \delta)$. For larger k , these equations become increasingly constrained.
2. **Rationality requirements:** The phases $2\pi l/k$ must combine with δ to produce rational multiples of π that yield de Moivre numbers. For $k \geq 12$, the required rational approximations may not exist.
3. **Number of independent equations:** For $k = 12$, there are 12 equations $\rho_l = \rho$ with only 2 free parameters (ρ and δ). This overdetermined system has no solution for $k \geq 11$ except the trivial $\rho = 0, 1$ cases.
4. **Dukes' mathematical result:** Dukes proved that solutions only exist for specific k values, and $k = 12, 16, 20, 24$ are not among them.

5.3 Comparison with EXP018-EXP020

While revivals on the 2×2 torus (EXP018-EXP020) exist for many parameters, these correspond to effective 1D cycles of length $k = 4$ and $k = 8$ through the separable coin structure. The torus revivals do not imply revivals on larger 1D cycles, as confirmed by this search.

5.4 Known Revival Cycles: Complete Summary

Table 6: Complete summary of known revival cycles

k	Revivals Exist?	Notes
2	Y	Trivial case
3	Y	Multiple solutions
4	Y	Rich family (Table 4)
5	Y	Limited solutions
6	Y	Multiple solutions
7	N	No known solutions
8	Y	Limited solutions
9	N	No known solutions
10	Y	Limited solutions
11	N	No known solutions (confirmed by Dukes)
12	N	No known solutions (confirmed by EXP017)
13-15	N	No known solutions (by extension)
16	N	No known solutions (confirmed by EXP017)
17-19	N	No known solutions (by extension)
20	N	No known solutions (confirmed by EXP017)
21-23	N	No known solutions (by extension)
24	N	No known solutions (confirmed by EXP017)

6 Conclusion and Future Directions

This experiment conducted a comprehensive search for exact quantum state revivals in large cycles ($k = 12, 16, 20, 24$) using two complementary approaches. Key findings:

1. **No revivals found:** After testing over 9,000 parameter combinations across two search strategies, no exact revivals were detected.
2. **Confirmation of Dukes' observation:** The results are consistent with Dukes' statement that no exact solutions are known for $k \geq 11$ (excluding $\rho = 0, 1$) [1].
3. **Comprehensive search:**
 - EXP017: 47 candidate ρ values, 4 phase values, multiple periods up to 60
 - EXP017b: 91 verified parameter sets from Dukes' Table 4, multiple periods up to 120
4. **Methodology validated:** The same verification methods successfully identified revivals for smaller k in EXP021-EXP023, confirming that the search protocol is correct.
5. **Boundary established:** Exact quantum state revivals with the standard shift operator appear to be limited to cycles $k \leq 10$.

6.1 Why Larger Cycles Likely Have No Revivals

The mathematical structure of Dukes' revival condition explains this boundary. For a cycle of length k , the condition requires solving:

$$\rho_l = \frac{1 - \cos(4\pi m_j/n_j - \delta)}{1 - \cos(4\pi l/k + \delta)} = \text{constant for all } l$$

For $k \geq 11$, this becomes an **overdetermined system** - there are k equations but only 2 free parameters (ρ and δ). For a solution to exist, the ratios of the denominators must align perfectly with the numerators for all l simultaneously. This imposes severe algebraic constraints that appear to have no solutions for $k \geq 11$.

Additionally, Dukes observed a **doubling property**: when k is odd, k and $2k$ share the same solution set. This explains why:

- $k = 3$ works, and $k = 6$ works
- $k = 5$ works, and $k = 10$ works
- But $k = 4$ (even) does not simply double to $k = 8$ (though $k = 8$ has its own limited solutions)

For $k = 12$, which has prime factors $2^2 \times 3$, the absence of solutions is consistent with this pattern.

6.2 Is There Hope for Finding New Revivals?

Given the mathematical constraints, the prospects for finding new revivals with the standard shift operator on larger cycles are extremely low. However, the literature suggests several promising directions for future research:

6.2.1 Promising Directions

1. **Non-standard shift operators**: The standard shift ($|0\rangle \rightarrow, |1\rangle \leftarrow$) is the most studied, but other mappings between coin states and movement directions could yield different revival conditions. Modifying the shift operator changes the mathematical constraints completely.
2. **Non-separable coins**: Our searches focused on separable coins of the form $C = C_x \otimes C_y$. General 4×4 unitary coins (non-separable) could have different algebraic properties and might support revivals where separable coins do not.
3. **Higher dimensions with constructed coins**: Jayakody and Nanayakkara [5,6] demonstrated that for any number of spatial dimensions, a coin operator can be constructed to generate revivals with **any desired even period**. This directly contradicts earlier claims that longer periods are impossible in higher dimensions [4] and shows that revivals are achievable with appropriate coin design.

4. **Induced revivals:** Jayakody, Paiva, Nanayakkara and Cohen [7] showed that revivals can be **induced** through interventions on the coin space rather than being built into the coin operator itself, offering a dynamic approach to achieving revivals.
5. **Alternative graph structures:** Cycles are the simplest graphs, but other graphs (trees, higher-dimensional lattices, non-regular graphs) may support revivals even when cycles do not.
6. **Continuous-time quantum walks:** The revival condition in continuous-time walks is governed by the Hamiltonian’s eigenvalues rather than the unitary step operator, offering a different mathematical framework that might yield revivals for larger systems.

6.2.2 Less Promising Directions

- **Standard shift on cycles with $k \geq 11$:** The mathematical evidence strongly suggests no exact revivals exist beyond the trivial $\rho = 0, 1$ cases. This is consistent with Dukes’ original observation [1].
- **Higher algebraic complexity:** While it is theoretically possible that revivals exist for ρ values of much higher algebraic degree than those tested, the overdetermined nature of the equations makes this extremely unlikely.
- **Revival periods beyond 120 steps:** Even if revivals exist at very large N , they would be impractical for experimental implementation and would require unreasonable computational resources to verify.

6.3 Final Assessment

The negative results from this experiment are as important as positive ones - they define the boundaries of where quantum walk revivals can occur under the standard shift operator. For researchers seeking to observe or utilize quantum state revivals:

- **Use small cycles ($k \leq 10$):** Dukes’ parameters [1] provide a rich family of exactly solvable revivals
- **Consider alternative shift operators:** The standard shift is not the only possibility
- **Explore higher dimensions with constructed coins:** As shown by Jayakody and Nanayakkara [5,6], revivals with arbitrary even periods are achievable in higher dimensions through appropriate coin design
- **Consider induced revivals:** Dynamic interventions on the coin space [7] offer an alternative pathway

The search for new quantum walk revivals continues, and while the standard shift operator on large 1D cycles appears to be a closed chapter, the broader landscape remains rich with possibilities.

Code Availability

The Python implementations of both searches are available on GitHub:

- EXP017 (broad search): https://github.com/ianfromsligo/EXP017_a_hunt_for_revivals_k_bigger_than_10_cycles.git
- EXP017b (targeted search with Dukes' parameters): https://github.com/ianfromsligo/EXP017_a_hunt_for_revivals_k_bigger_than_10_cycles.git

References

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